

costs incurred were high with little or no returns. "We spent a lot of time and money developing our products, but didn't spend enough time developing the services around Linux essential for returns from the products we developed," says Abhas, with regret.

Team building. An early hurdle

Apart from financial obstacles, DeepRoot had other problems. "Developing a team of product developers was a challenge, as very few had the vision to develop products, nor could they dedicate themselves full-time towards developing FOSS solutions," says Abhas.

Clear skies at last

The early bumpy rides of the company became smooth after it struck a few deals. The flexibility possible due to a young and fresh team, with radical marketing strategies, helped the team win orders. "Striking our first deal was a challenge and we got it by participating in the IT.Com Convention. Though we didn't have a product to showcase, we set up a stall and distributed brochures of DeepRoot. This participation got us attention and also our first few orders for developing products, services and localisation. In 2001, we again took part in the convention and continued such marketing activities to let people know about us, our solutions and services. This helped us build our business in the initial stages," Abhas recalls.

Meanwhile, the inexperience of the team seemed to be a boon rather than a bane for DeepRoot. The young team members were more flexible, displaying tremendous fervour to sell products. "The lack of experience resulted in no preconceived notions about the client's acceptance of a new solution provider. We placed no limitations on what we could or ought to do. This openness helped us keep up the enthusiasm when trying to sell, ultimately resulting in closing deals."

The first handshakes

DeepRoot's first client was an ISP in Hyderabad run by a seasoned businessman. "Back then, we developed server appliances that had to be plugged in to run the

systems. We integrated LCD modules in it like the ones you see in PCO machines with keypads, etc. This caught the eye of the Hyderabad-based company, which wanted the same for their products. We built the entire software and hardware for their product. Alongside, we released the software developed as FOSS," says Abhas.

The first services client was a company specialising in developing embedded software, called software for 'controller area network' (CANs), for cars. "The firm used Linux in its office. We provided file services, domain authentication, BNP, e-mail, a firewall, and proxy services," reports Abhas.

Lessons learnt

During the initial phases, DeepRoot learnt that selling FOSS solutions by talking of Linux alone wouldn't work as a business strategy. People needed holistic workable solutions around GNU/Linux. "We realised that the only way to sell Linux was by selling a complete Linux package—products addressing the customer's concern with readily available services and support," said Abhas. DeepRoot used hardware resellers, systems integrators and distribution chains to push this complete package.

DeepRoot today

Fast forwarding to the present, DeepRoot has come a long way from its infancy. It has developed a revenue-generating business model and offers a range of solutions and services around Linux, catering to multiple sectors, namely education, aerospace, healthcare, insurance, manufacturing, cement, iron and steel, garment exports, non-profit organisations, newspapers/publications, software services, semiconductors, government and defence, BPO, financial services, Web hosting, ISP and retail.

The solutions the company provides include distributed e-mail, unified authentication, thin client solutions, directory services, link management, file serving and storage solutions, request tracking and helpdesks, firewalls and VPNs, mail server clusters, proxy servers, etc. The solutions are built on the deepofox mail server and powered by Debian GNU/

"FOSS has tremendous business opportunities as first, many sectors like SMEs cannot afford proprietary software and second, a lot of the software problems in India are very local."

—Abhas Abhinav

